

information, and learned the science behind it. Coach Tellez and I even wrote a book about the science of running. I studied and then put that knowledge into practice. Coach Tellez would watch the sessions and say, "This is right; that's wrong." It wasn't like I just decided to start coaching. I actually put in the time. I couldn't simply say, 'I'm Carl Lewis — I know what I'm talking about!'

Why did you feel the need to do that? After all, you are Carl Lewis!

The bottom line is that my name brings both opportunities and challenges. It's definitely an advantage, and wherever my name can help, I use it. But when it comes to athletics, I had to put in the work. I don't shy away from that.

Is there a medal that stands out for you?

A few. My first Olympic medal stands out, as does my 100m gold at the Tokyo World Championships. And, finally, my last Olympic medal in Atlanta — those three mean the most. But I've donated all my medals to the Smithsonian National Museum of African American History and Culture in Washington, D.C., so anyone can see them. I don't keep any at home. I did that because I understand the power of an Olympic medal. When people see it, they melt.

Last year, one of our University of Houston athletes — Shawn Maswanganyi — brought his medal to campus and showed it to the university president. She held it with such pride. That's what I wanted for my medals, too. If they sit in my house, no one gets to share that magic. I also have a granddaughter. One day, when I'm gone, I want her, or her children, to be able to go to the museum and say, 'That's my papa.'

What does being called the greatest ever mean to you?

It's funny because people say,

"You're one of the greatest athletes of all time," and billions may know you or love you. But I still have to shave. I still have to watch what I eat. I still have to exercise. Every morning, when the alarm goes off, I still think, Oh man, I don't want to get out of bed. It reminds me that I'm just like everyone else, whether I was one of the greatest or not.

It's interesting that you mention the mundane things, because there must have come a time when age started catching up. How did you deal with that?

I always knew it was coming. I was never afraid of that phase of life, and I wasn't going to compete once I couldn't be competitive. I didn't want to drag my career on.

After Atlanta, I think I could have gone all the way to Sydney. I really do. Maybe not definitely, but I think I could have won at 39. Still, I knew it

« **The long jump world record that Mike Powell holds. I never got that one. That's probably the only thing. I love Mike; we actually talk about it a lot. I have a lot of respect for him**

— Carl Lewis »

was time to move on. My life was expanding in other ways, and that's probably why that transition didn't bother me.

You competed in an era full of incredible rivalries — Ben Johnson, Mike Powell. What did that competition mean to you?

Competition was vital. My focus was always on running the best race in my lane. The rivalries inspired me to work harder and to stay in front.

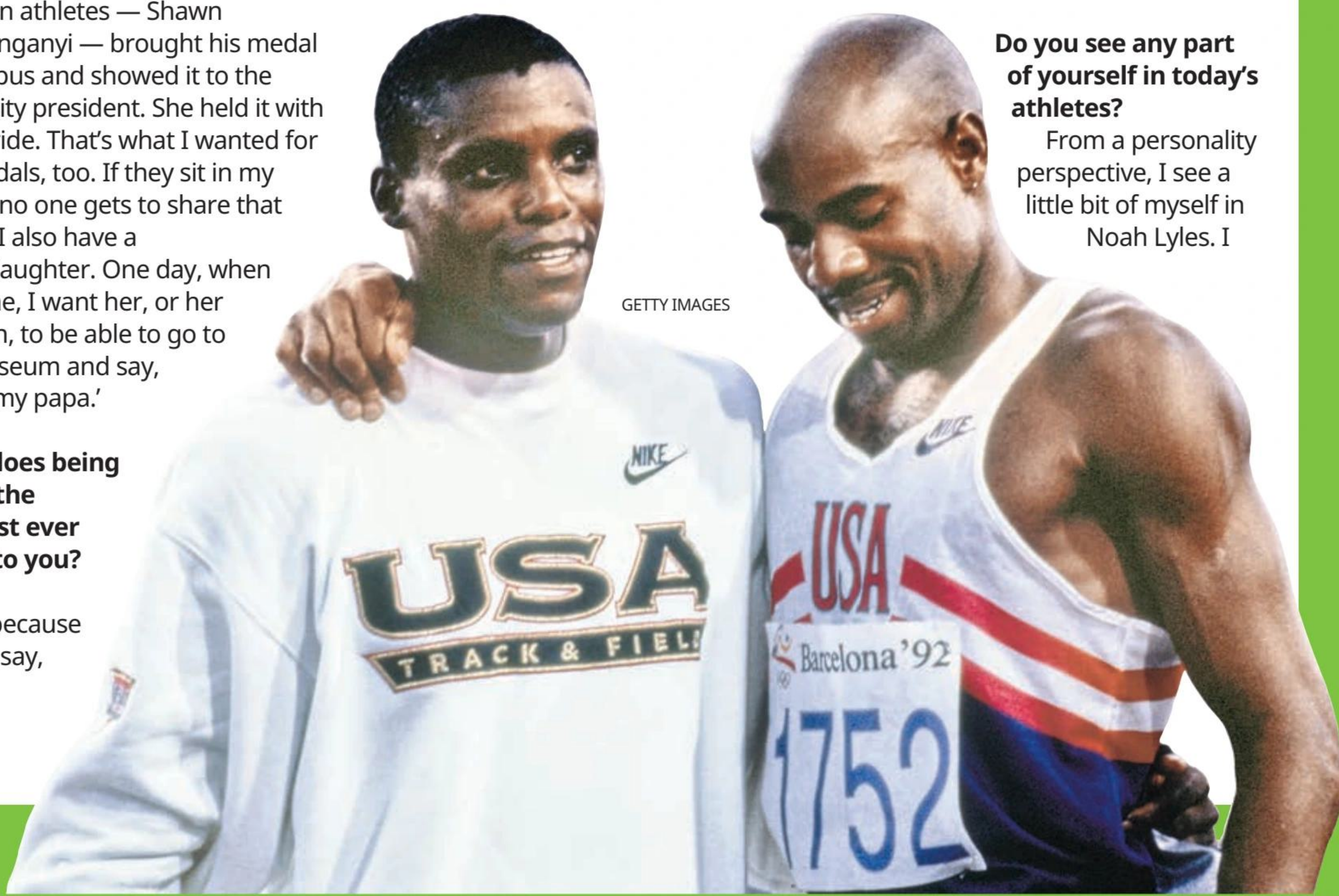
You also had a reputation for arrogance. How much of that was real, and how much was performance psychology?

You build your confidence; you prepare for it. When I went into major Championships, I was always ready — that's where my confidence came from. It came from preparation, hard work, and making sure every detail was covered.

I ran a lot of events, but the Championships mattered most. I competed in four World Championships and four Olympic Games. In 1993, I was in a car accident, so I wasn't at 100 per cent. But even then, I made the 100m and 200m finals. I didn't do the long jump because of the injury, but I was still ready. I also got sick with Giardia in 1994, so 1995 was difficult. But I knew I could still perform. I told myself, 'I'm going to give it one more shot — and then I'm done.'

Do you see any part of yourself in today's athletes?

From a personality perspective, I see a little bit of myself in Noah Lyles. I



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